

Introduction

md-publisher turns a folder of mdpub files into DOCX, PDF, Web, and EPUB output from one command. This guide walks through installing the CLI, building your first Publication, and where to go next.

See [Setup](#) to install the CLI, or jump straight to [Advanced Topics](#) if you already have it running. For every construct md-publisher supports, with its syntax and rendered output side by side, see the [Syntax Reference](#).

Setup

Install md-publisher-cli globally with npm, then create a Publication: a directory of mdpub files, numbered so their filenames sort into the chapter order you want.

Run the generate command against that directory, naming the Build Targets you want. Output is written to a dist folder next to where you ran the command.

See Introduction for the big picture, or continue to Advanced Topics.

Advanced Topics

Cross-References

A link like this one pointing at Setup only resolves if a heading named Setup exists somewhere in the Publication. If it does not, the build refuses to produce any output at all until the Structure Violation is fixed.

Table of Contents

EPUB output needs exactly one chapter whose front matter marks it as the table-of-contents source, which is what the Introduction chapter does.

See the Syntax Reference for every construct md-publisher supports, or Introduction to start over from the beginning.

Syntax Reference

Every construct md-publisher understands, with its raw syntax shown as a code block followed by what it actually renders as. See Setup if you have not installed the CLI yet, or the project README for the exact scope (a practical CommonMark superset, not the full spec).

Headings

Syntax:

```
# Heading level 1
```

```
## Heading level 2
```

```
##### Heading level 6 (the deepest level supported)
```

Every heading in this Publication (including this one) is a live example — headings are not inline-parsed, so emphasis or links inside heading text are not supported.

Paragraphs and Line Breaks

Syntax:

A paragraph is one or more lines with no blank line between them.

A soft-wrapped second line like this one joins the first with a single space.

A blank line starts a new paragraph.

End a line with a trailing backslash\

or two or more trailing spaces to force a hard line break within one paragraph.

Output: this sentence is deliberately wrapped onto a second source line with no blank line in between, and renders as one paragraph joined by a space, not two.

This is a new paragraph, started only because a blank line came before it.

This line ends with a trailing backslash

so the text after it starts on its own line, within the same paragraph as the line above.

Emphasis and Strong

Syntax:

```
*emphasis* or _emphasis_
```

```
**strong** or __strong__
```

Output: emphasis, emphasis (the same thing, two spellings), strong, strong (also the same thing, two spellings).

Code Spans

Syntax:

Use ``inline code`` like this, for a variable name or a short command.

Output: use inline code like this, for a variable name or a short command.

Fenced Code Blocks

Syntax (shown here inside a ~~~-fenced block so the ``` fence itself can appear literally):

```
```js
const x = 1;
console.log(x);
```
```

Output:

```
const x = 1;
console.log(x);
```

The language after the opening fence (js above) is optional and carried through as a CSS class on Web/EPUB output for syntax-highlighting tools to key off; DOCX and PDF render the content in a monospace font regardless of language.

Blockquotes

Syntax:

```
> A blockquote line.
> A second line joins the first as one paragraph inside the quote.

>> A nested quote (one more leading ">" per level).
```

Output:

A blockquote line. A second line joins the first as one paragraph inside the quote.

A nested quote — one level deeper than the one above.

Lists

Syntax:

- An unordered item
- Another item
 - A nested item (indent it under the item it belongs to)
- Back at the outer level

1. An ordered item
2. Another ordered item

Output:

- An unordered item
- Another item
 - A nested item

- Back at the outer level

1. An ordered item
2. Another ordered item

Note: a list item's own content is always exactly one line — there is no continuation-line support for a single item spanning multiple paragraphs.

Images

Syntax:

```
![A short diagram](diagram.png)
```

Output: [Image: A short diagram]

Image syntax is fully supported everywhere above, but embedding the actual file is not finished yet: Web/EPUB reference the path as written (broken unless you copy the file alongside the output yourself), and DOCX/PDF currently render a [Image: alt text] placeholder instead of the picture.

Links and Cross-References

Syntax:

```
[An external link](https://example.com)
```

```
[A cross-reference to a heading in this Publication](#setup)
```

Output: an external link goes anywhere on the web with no validation. Setup is a cross-reference — md-publisher checks at build time (and live, as you type) that a heading named "Setup" actually exists somewhere in the Publication, and refuses to generate any output at all if it does not.

Thematic Breaks

Syntax:

```
---
```

(*** and ____ work identically.) Output, immediately below this paragraph:

See Introduction to start over, or Advanced Topics for how Structure Violations and the EPUB table-of-contents marker work.